junked a letter by SSM secretary Vijay Jhala demanding stern action against Gadhvi. This has created tension between the RSS outfit and the state government. "There were some 1,250 cases of atrocities against SCs registered in Gujarat (except Saurashtra) in the past year. This is worrisome," says Jhala.

The RSS and the Patel government have been on a collision course over the handling of such cases. In November 2021, RSS Gujarat *prant sanghchalak* Bharat Patel had to publicly condemn the attack on an SC family of six in Kutch for entering a temple and put pressure on the government before it announced a compensation of Rs 21 lakh for the victims. Ten people were finally arrested in the incident. In April, the RSS and the state government faced off again after Jignesh Mevani, the livewire Dalit leader and Independent MLA from Badgam, was arrested in Banaskantha by the Assam police for an alleged derogatory social media post on PM Modi. The RSS believes the "unnecessary" action made Mevani a hero and gave him more ammunition against the government. "We had started cornering Mevani in a planned manner," says an RSS functionary, "but his arrest created a sympathy wave for him. He has now revived his anti-Hindutva agenda."

It has proved true, since his release on bail on April 29, the firebrand leader has been hyperactive in north and central Gujarat, addressing rallies and meeting people. The response has been overwhelming and has BJP supporters worried. Mevani says he will continue his fight against the oppression of the underprivileged. "As a person, Bhupendra Patel is a gentleman, but his government has failed us completely," Mevani told INDIA TODAY. He highlights the infamous incident in Una where Dalits were flogged in 2017. "No chargesheet has been filed in the case even after five years," he says.

## THE KITCHEN CABINET

**The team of bureaucrats the first-time MLA and CM has been largely dependent on**



**Pankaj Joshi**
*Additional chief secretary*
The 1989-batch IAS officer helms the chief minister's office. Energy, petrochemicals and infrastructure have been the forte of the ex-IITian



**Avantika Singh**
*Principal secy*
Known as the CM's eyes and ears, the 2003-batch IAS officer is considered to be one of the most influential bureaucrats in Gujarat. Had an impressive run as Ahmedabad collector



**K. Kailasnathan**
*Chief principal secretary*
Retired in 2017 but was reappointed as chief principal secretary. An expert in water management, and a veteran analyst of state affairs



**M.D. Modia**
*OSD, CM's office*
The 2006-batch IAS officer was collector of Bharuch before being elevated to the CM's office as one of the two OSDs. A trusted official, he looks after the CM's engagements



**Nimesh Dave**
*OSD*
As deputy commissioner in Ahmedabad Municipal Corporation, the 2012-batch IAS officer has been a witness to CM Patel's rise. Dave has been a trusted confidant since then

### Political games

When it comes to political manoeuvring, CM Patel takes a back seat to the aggressive state BJP president Patil. The latter has planned a massive 'booth-level' campaign between June 12 and 14, where the 12,000 state office-bearers will visit every ward and interact with workers and voters. Frontal organisations like the women's wing and the SC/ ST, OBC and youth wings have to meet 300 party workers from every caste. Prominent BJP leaders have been asked to adopt one of the 48,312 children on the state's malnourished list for a year. They will be responsible for the children's diet and health. Meanwhile, the party poached the face of the Patidar reservation protests, Hardik Patel, from the Congress on June 2. His entry should boost the BJP's ties with the community.

In 2017, the Congress campaign had a tagline, '*Vikas gando che* (Development has gone berserk)'. In a counter, the BJP had come up with '*Hun chhu vikas, hun chhu Gujarat* (I am development, I am Gujarat)'. A senior BJP leader says the campaign this time will focus on six points—Modi, *karyakarta* (worker), *vikas*, *jan vishvaas* (public trust), *vyavastha* (system) and *vatavaran* (work culture). "That will be enough for us to win the election," he feels.

Bhupendra Patel had pointed out in March that Gujarat's fiscal deficit has not touched 2 per cent post-Covid despite the Centre allowing a leeway of up to 4.5 per cent. "That is because of good governance," he had claimed at the time. The CM had also outlined his top priorities—taking care of the last man in the queue as well as reducing the carbon footprint. When asked about Modi, Patel smiled. "We have to take forward the good work initiated by him...there is only one Narendra Modi and no one can match him in the entire world," he had said. That about sums up the CM's position on a lot many things in the state. ■